Alexandra Nisenoff

nisenoff@cmu.edu | anisenoff.github.io

Education

Carnegie Mellon University — **August 2022 — Present**, Pittsburgh, PA
Ph.D. student, Societal Computing, School of Computer Science
M.S. in Societal Computing May 2024
Advisors: Nicolas Christin and Lorrie Faith Cranor
Thesis Committee: Nicolas Christin, Lorrie Faith Cranor, Lujo Bauer, Blase Ur, Deian Stefan
GPA: 4.06

University of Chicago, Summa Cum Laude — **September 2017 — June 2021**, Chicago, IL
B.S. in Computer Science (specialization in computer security)
B.A. Astrophysics
GPS: 3.737

Research

Carnegie Mellon University, Software and Societal Systems Department — **August 2022 — Present**
Research Assistant for Prof. Nicolas Christin and Prof. Lorrie Faith Cranor — *Pittsburgh, PA*

University of Chicago, Department of Computer Science, SUPERgroup — **July 2019 — August 2022**
Research Assistant for Prof. Blase Ur — *Chicago, IL*

University of Chicago, Data Science Institute — **August 2020 — July 2022**
Research Assistant for Prof. Nick Feamster — *Chicago, IL*

Max Planck Institute for Security and Privacy — **June 2021 — September 2021**
Human Factors in Security and Privacy Group — Remote
Research Assistant for Prof. Yasemin Acar

University of Chicago, Department of Astronomy and Astrophysics — **October 2019 — December 2021**
Research Assistant for Prof. Vikram Dwarkadas — *Chicago, IL*

University of Chicago, Department of Geophysical Sciences — **June 2018 — March 2019**
Lab Technician for Prof. Elisabeth Moyer — *Chicago, IL*

Presentations & Publications

Peer Reviewed Conference Papers

[CCS '25] **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Deian Stefan, Nicolas Christin. *Exploiting the Shared Storage API.* In Proceedings of the 32nd ACM Conference on Computer and Communication Security. Taipei, Taiwan. October 2025.

[SOUPS '24] Elijah Bouma-Sims, Hiba Hassan, **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Lorrie Faith Cranor, and Nicolas Christin. *"It was honestly just gambling": Investigating the Experiences of Teenage Cryptocurrency Users on Reddit*. Proceedings of the 20th Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security. Philadelphia, PA, August 2024.

[USENIX '23] **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Maximilian Golla, Miranda Wei, Juliette Hainline, Hayley Szymanek, Annika Braun, Annika Hildebrandt, Blair Christensen, David Langenberg, and Blase Ur. *A Two-Decade Retrospective Analysis of a University's Vulnerability to Attacks Exploiting Reused Passwords*. Proceedings of the 32nd USENIX Security Symposium. Anaheim, CA, August 2023.
Distinguished Paper Award

[USENIX '23] **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Arthur Borem, Madison Pickering, Grant Nakanishi, Maya Thumpasery, and Blase Ur. *Defining "Broken": User Experiences and Remediation Tactics When Ad-Blocking or Tracking-Protection Tools Break a Website's User Experience*. Proceedings of the 32nd USENIX Security Symposium. Anaheim, CA, August 2023.

[USENIX '23] **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Ranya Sharma, Nick Feamster. *User Awareness and Behaviors Concerning Encrypted DNS Settings in Web Browsers*. Proceedings of the 32nd USENIX Security Symposium. Anaheim, CA, August 2023.

[CHI '23] Elijah Bouma-Sims, Megan Li, Yanzi Lin, Adia Sakura-Lemessy, **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Ellie Young, Eleanor Birrell, Lorrie Faith Cranor, and Hana Habib. *A US-UK Usability Evaluation of Consent Management Platform Cookie Consent Interface Design on Desktop and Mobile.* Proceedings of the ACM SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems. Hamburg, Germany. April 2023.

[USENIX '22] Collins Munyendo, Philipp Markert, **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Miles Grant, Elena Korkes, Blase Ur, Adam Aviv. *"The Same PIN, Just Longer:" On the (In)Security of Upgrading PINs from 4 to 6 Digits.* Proceedings of the 31st USENIX Security Symposium. Boston, MA, August 2022.

Peer Reviewed Journal Papers

- Eman Alashwali, Andrea Miller, **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Kyerra Norton, Ellie Young, Prerna Bothra, Mandy Lanyon, and Lorrie Faith Cranor. *Interface Design to Support Informed Choices When Users Face Numerous Privacy Decisions,* in IEEE Transactions on Privacy, vol. 2, pp. 79-91, 2025.

Peer Reviewed Workshop Papers

- **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Nick Feamster, Madeleine A Hoofnagle, Sydney Zink. *User Expectations and Understanding of Encrypted DNS Settings.* In Network and Distributed Security Symposium Workshop on DNS Privacy, pp. 1-8, Virtual. February 2021.

Other Publications

- **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Maximilian Golla, Blase Ur. *Measuring the Risk Password Reuse Poses for a University.* USENIX ;login: Magazine, July 2023.
- **Alexandra Nisenoff**, Vikram V. Dwarkadas, Mathias C. Ross. *Supernova X-Ray Database (SNaX) Updated to Ensure Long-term Stability*. 2020 Res. Notes AAS 4 195.

Posters

- *Exploiting the Shared Storage API*. CyLab Partners Conference. 2025.
- *The State of Privacy Sandbox Attestation on the Web*. CyLab Partners Conference. 2024.
- *Defining "Broken": User Experiences and Remediation Tactics When Ad-Blocking or Tracking-Protection Tools Break a Website's User Experience*. CRA Grad Cohort Workshop. 2023.
- *Exploiting Side-Channels in the Shared Storage API to Reidentify Users Across Websites*. CyLab Partners Conference. 2023.

Fellowships & Grants

Research Funding

- **CyLab Presidential Fellowship**, a year of tuition given to high-achieving PhD students pursuing security/privacy research **2025**
- **National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship** **2022**
- **Dean's Fund Grant**, $1,500 UChicago grant for research expenses **2020**
- **Jeff Metcalf Fellowship Grant**, $3,750 UChicago grant for summer internships **2020**

Travel Grants

- **Student Grant to attend CCS** **2025**
- **Student Grant to attend USENIX Security** **2023**
- **Grant to attend GREPSEC** **2023**
- **Scholarship to CRA Grad Cohort Workshop** **2023**
- **Diversity Grant to attend USENIX Enigma** **2020**

Awards

PETS '25 Distinguished Artifact Reviewer **2025**

USENIX '23 Distinguished Paper Award for "A Two-Decade Retrospective Analysis of a University's Vulnerability to . . . " **2023**

Departmental Honors (Computer Science) **2021**

Harper Award for Exceptional Performance in a Course, Engineering Interactive Electronics onto Printed Circuit Boards **2021**

Enrico Fermi Scholar, GPA in top 5% of major over past 5 years (only eligible 3rd and 4th year of college) **2020 & 2021**

Dean's List **2017 — 2020**

Service

Reviewing

- **CCS:** Security Usability and Measurement Track Program Committee Member **2026**
- **The Web Conference:** Security and Privacy Track Program Committee Member **2025, 2026**

- **MADWeb:** Program Committee Member — **2026**
- **CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems:** External Reviewer — **2024, 2025, 2026**
- **USENIX Security:** Artifact Review Committee Member — **2025**
- **PoPETs:** Artifact Review Committee Member — **2023, 2024, 2025**
- **USENIX Security:** Poster Jury — **2025**
- **SOUPS:** Poster Jury — **2024, 2025**

Other

- **S3D Societal Computing CyLab Student Rep** — **2025 — Present**
- **S3D PhD Admissions Committee:** Student Member — **2026**
- **Cylab Faculty Hiring Committee:** Student Member — **2025**
- **Graduate Application Support Program – School of Computer Science**
  - Program Organizer — **2025**
  - Graduate Student Mentor — **2022, 2023, 2024**
- **REU in Software Engineering (REUSE)**: Admissions Committee Member — **2024, 2025**
- **SCS Gender Minority Lunch Social:** S3D Department Student Organizer — **2024 — 2025**

Teaching

- **Teaching Assistant**, Carnegie Mellon University, **Introduction to Computer Security** - Undergrad
  (Instructors: Riccardo Paccagnella & Riad Wahby; 99 students) — **Spring 2025**
  (Instructors: David Brumley & Riad Wahby; 110 students) — **Spring 2024**
- **Head Teaching Assistant**, Carnegie Mellon University, **Usable Privacy & Security** - Undergrad/Master's/PhD
  (Instructor: Lorrie Cranor; 61 students) — **Spring 2023**
- **Teaching Assistant**, University of Chicago, **Introduction to Computer Security** - Undergrad/PhD
  (Instructors: David Cash & Blase Ur; 109 students) — **Winter 2022**
  (Instructors: David Cash & Blase Ur; 86 students) — **Winter 2021**
- **Guest Lectures**
  - **Browser Security**, INI, Carnegie Mellon University
    - **When Web Security and Privacy Mechanisms Fail** — **March 2026**
    - **Advancements in Privacy Preserving Advertising *(and how things can go wrong)***, — **February 2025**
  - **Intro to Computer Security**, CSD/ECE, Carnegie Mellon University
    - **Making Security Usable** — **November 2025**
    - **Making Security Usable** — **April 2025**
  - **Intro to Information Security**, ECE, Carnegie Mellon University
    - **Intro to Web Security** — **March 2026**
    - **Intro to Web Security** — **March 2025**
- **Computer Science Tutor**, University of Chicago, College Core Tutor Program — **Winter 2020**

Activities & Outreach

TechNights – Carnegie Mellon University — **October 2023 — May 2025**
Volunteer — *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Facilitated CS related activities for 20-30 middle school girls
- Spring '25 helped lead a session on ethical hacking and IoT security

OurCS – Carnegie Mellon University — **October 2022, 2024**
Graduate Student Mentor — *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Worked with another PhD student to run a two day mini research project for undergraduate students on cookie consent categories ('22) and anti-adblock banners ('24)

Expanding Your Horizons Chicago — **August 2019 — March 2022**
Organizing Committee Member — *Chicago, IL*

- Organized student recruitment for annual STEM symposium for middle school girls

Skills

Programming	Python, C, LabVIEW, JavaScript, PHP, and R
Applications	Adobe Lightroom, Qualtrics, and LaTeX
Hobbies	Flamework, Quilting, Embroidery, Crocheting, Knitting, Sewing, Photography (Film/Digital), Bobbin Lace Making